

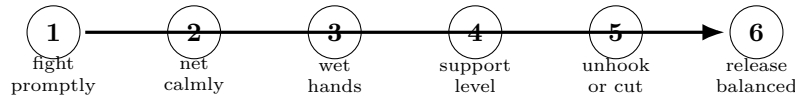
Handling & Release

ChatGPT edition

Prepare before the bite

Build the release station

Match tackle to the largest plausible fish. Open pliers and cutters; wet and stage a knotless rubber net; set the camera before casting. Decide whether the fish can remain beside the boat.



Before-cast check

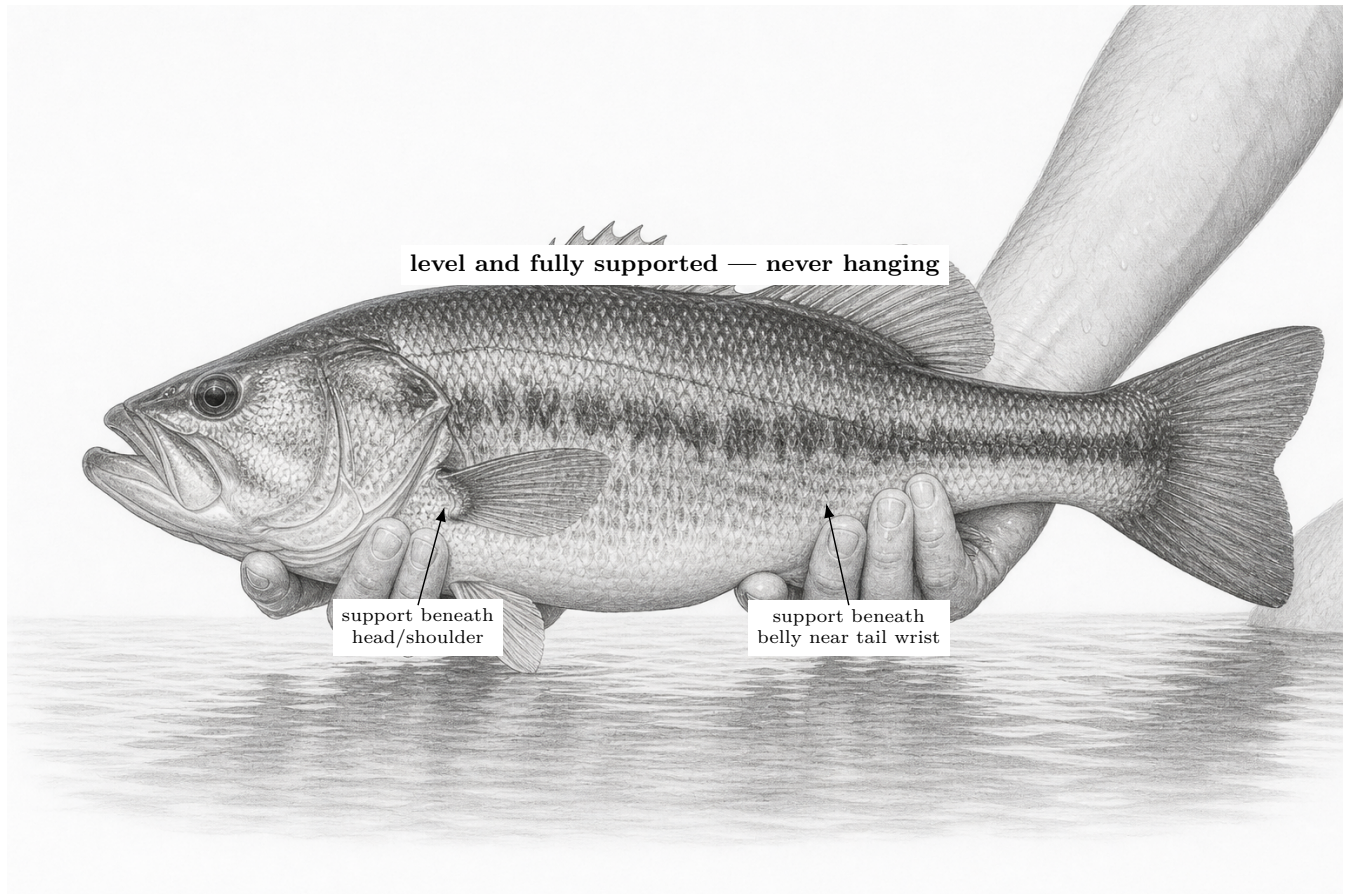
Pliers open one-handed; cutters sever the actual leader; net is untangled and wet; measuring board is ready; camera is awake. If release is likely, favor tackle that limits deep hooking.

At the fish: decide at each gate

1. **Control.** Use steady pressure and adequate tackle. If the fish still surges, keep it in water; do not drag it onto a dry floor.
2. **Net or boatside?** Net only when it reduces handling. Guide the fish headfirst; never chase its tail with the hoop.
3. **Hook access?** Back out an exposed hook with the fish supported. If deep extraction is slow or destructive, cut the line promptly.
4. **Photo?** Only if camera and hands are ready. Lift horizontally, close to the water, then return it without delay.
5. **Release.** Support upright in water. Let go when it holds balance and swims under its own power; face gentle current only when one exists.

Ask mid-process: Is the next action for the fish, or for the picture? Has air exposure stopped being brief? Would cutting now cause less injury?

Support map



Avoid	Observable correction
Dry hands / dry deck	Skin remains glossy and wet; fish touches wet net or wet hands, not carpet or clothing.
Vertical jaw hold	Second hand carries body weight; spine stays nearly level.
Gill contact	Fingers remain outside gill plate and away from eyes.
Repeated measuring	Use a hard-stop board once; release immediately if short.
Violent “reviving”	Hold balanced without pumping. Movement is self-directed.

Troubleshooting the release

Observation	Response
Fish rolls on its side	Keep supported upright in water; reduce handling. If legal harvest is not an option, give it quiet time rather than pumping.
Hook will not reverse	Expose only what is necessary; cut hook or line with staged cutters instead of tearing tissue.
Fish repeatedly caught deep	Change target depth, location, tackle, or species; do not keep proving the same harm.
Warm fish fights poorly	Shorten the fight and air time; consider ending or changing the trip before another capture.

DEPTH AND TEMPERATURE

Deep capture and warm water increase risk. Wisconsin DNR does not recommend artificial swim-bladder deflation. Change location, depth, tackle, or target rather than repeatedly producing fish unlikely to survive.

Release verified: the fish remains upright without hand pressure, shows coordinated fin movement, and leaves under its own power.

Field proof worksheet

Time / place	One action taken	Direct observation	Pass, fail, or next action
--------------	------------------	--------------------	----------------------------

Close the loop
Claim: What do I now think is true?
Evidence: What did I see, feel, measure, or repeat?
Fault ruled out: What alternative explanation did I check?
Next single action: What one change will test the claim?

Final proof

Do not mark complete because every written step was attempted. Mark complete only when the guide’s observable pass condition is present, the safety chain is intact, and another person could repeat the action from this record. If the result is ambiguous, record a fail and choose one corrective action.

Source: Wisconsin DNR Catch-and-Release Guidelines.

Telos. Lake Country Fishing — Handling & Release. Revised 20260727.001. Project-created text and diagrams are licensed CC BY 4.0. Incorporated public-domain artwork remains public domain and is credited on the plate it appears with. See LICENSE and CREDITS.md in the source. Nothing here is professional advice; verify current regulations and follow the stated safety procedure.